

CODE-SWITCHING IN NIGERIAN CHRISTIAN SONGS

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Abstract

This paper investigates the phenomenon of code-switching and also the types of code-switching that occur in gospel songs. Therefore, using purposive random sampling and Poplack's (1980) model, the excerpts of from ten gospel songs are collected and analysed. Findings reveal that the most dominant type of codeswitching that occurs in Christian music is inter-sentential code switching while others like intra-switching and tag switching occur rather sparingly. Also, the English language and Pidgin, according to the findings, remain the most dominant language being code switched with indigenous languages. To this end, it can be asserted that code-switching is not only a recurring decimal in Christian songs but also a manifestation of a brand of music that can be labelled Nigerian gospel music.

Introduction

The Nigerian music industry today is swarming with different kinds of artistes, each with different kind of songs and lyrics. One peculiar features of the Nigerian music industry however is the tendency to use English alongside several other languages- a recurrent decimal that has become all too obvious to many lovers of Nigerian music today. While this may be considered as mere entertainment in some quarters; to linguists, this trend can be investigated linguistically, but then since music itself is meant to communicate something, an idea, a culture, a belief, a doctrine etc. through language.

In the Nigerian context, many languages exist and are used for different communication purposes, and are often designated foreign language (e.g. English,

French, and German etc.) or indigenous languages (e.g. Hausa, Igbo and Yoruba among several others). Some scholars even classify them into indigenous, exogenous and indi-exogenous language like Pidgin.

The implication of this linguistic pluralism is that terms like bilingualism, borrowing, code switching and code mixing have recurrent linguistic features over time; and as such, speakers of a given language will have a wide variety to make deliberate or conscious linguistic choices given the different linguistic codes at their disposal; however, the language aptitude and attitude of the language users among other linguistic parameters often come to bear. Nevertheless, this linguistic reality which is a clear manifestation of languages in contact has its pros and cons. Be that as it may, Nigerian musicians or artistes have benefited from this linguistic pluralism highlighted thus far, producing songs that have a blend of many Nigerian languages much to the delight of many numerous fans across the country and beyond. In the North where Hausa is the dominant lingua franca, there is a tendency for many music artistes there to adopt English language as well as Hausa in their songs, and this situation is expected to in other regions. To this end, some Christian songs are not left out of this trend. Consequently, these songs will serve as a case in point to justify the prevalence of code-switching in Christian songs.

Statement of the Problem

While code-switching is not a recent phenomenon in the lyric and study of secular music or non-religious songs, very little or no work has been written on this linguistic occurrence in Christian religious songs. Moreover, while it appears that many papers like Babalola (2009), Olarunfemi (2009) and Guerrero (2009) among others seem to stress the impact or prevalence of code switching in hip hop and traditional music respectively, this paper is concerned with the linguistic content of religious songs with a view to finding cases of code-switching in them.

Basic Assumptions of this Paper

This paper rests on the following assumptions:

- That code-switching occurs in Christian music or non-secular music
- That there is a preponderance of inter-sentential code-switching in gospel songs than any other type of code switching
- That intra-sentential code-switching only occurs minimally in the Christian songs compared to inter-sentential code switching
- That tag switching hardly occurs or occurs minimally in Christian songs
- That code-switching does not occur between a lexical stem and a bound morpheme but on “utterance construction level” and

- That this “utterance construction level” is used as a reference to the lyrics in the lines of Christian songs dismissed as “excerpts” in this paper

Methodology

Using ten (10) songs from Christian artistes or gospel musicians, this paper seeks to unveil the advent of code switching in Christian songs. Using two (2) excerpts only from these songs, this paper attempts to justify the existence of the following type of code switching:

- (a) Inter-sentential code switching
- (b) Intra-sentential code switching
- (c) Tag switching
- (d) Word switching

Inter-sentential switching occurs outside the sentence or the clause (i.e. at the sentence or the clause boundaries). It is sometimes called “extra-sentential”. Intraswitching on the other hand occurs within a sentence or a clause. Also, tag switching is the switching of either a tag phrase or word, or both, from one language to another (McClure, 2001, p.166).

Theoretical Framework:

Constraint-Bases Model: Poplack’s (1980)

The major backdrop of this model or theory is that it provides for the classification of code switching that exists and which is deployed in the analysis of data as is the case here. They include inter-sentential, intra-sentential and tag switching and word switching. This theory is predicted on two major constraints: the freemorpheme constraints and the free equivalence constraints. The former rests on the assumption that code-switching cannot occur between lexical stem and bound morphemes. Essentially, this constraint distinguishes code-switching from borrowing. Generally borrowing occurs in the lexicon, while code-switching occurs at either the syntax level or the utterance construction level.

The equivalence constraint predicts that the switches occur only at points where the surface structures of the languages coincide, or between sentence elements that are normally ordered in the same way by each individual grammar. To a large extent therefore, this paper seeks to use this model specifically the “free morpheme constraint” as a yardstick to test the validity or otherwise of the major propositions of this theory. Therefore, code-switching, in this context, will not occur between a lexical stem and a bound morpheme but on “utterance construction level” investigated using excerpts from Christian songs.

Code-switching